WordPress Beginner Course — Class 4 Lesson Plan

Class 4: Themes — Making Your Site Beautiful

■ Duration: 60 minutes · ■ Level: Absolute beginner · ■ Format: Online, screen-share demo + students follow along

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■ Learning Objectives

By the end of this class, every student should be able to:

1. Explain what a WordPress theme is and what it controls
2. Install and activate a free theme from WordPress.org directory
3. Explain the difference between **Block Themes (FSE)** and **Classic Themes**
4. Use **Site Editor** to change colors, typography, logo, and header/footer
5. Preview and switch themes safely

■ Prerequisites

- Class 3 completed: Live WordPress site + wp-admin access
- Site Title & Tagline set, Permalinks set to Post Name
- Ask at start: *"Everyone can see your live site? Type YES in chat"*

■ Class Timeline (60 min)

Block 1 — What is a Theme? (10 min)

Talking points / script:

> "If WordPress is the house, your content (posts/pages) is the furniture. The **theme** is the paint, interior design, and layout — it controls how your site LOOKS, not what it says. Same content can look completely different with different themes."

Live demo:

1. Show 3 sites with same content but different themes (use WordPress Theme Directory previews)
2. Show before/after: Switch from Twenty Twenty-Four to Astra live — same About Me page, different look
3. Emphasize: Changing theme does NOT delete your posts/pages

Block 2 — Installing & Activating Themes (15 min)

Live demo steps (share your screen):

1. Go to **Appearance** → **Themes**
2. Click **Add New Theme**
3. Show the directory: Featured, Popular, Filters (e.g., filter: Blog, E-commerce)
4. Search for: **Astra** / **Blocksy** / **Twenty Twenty-Four** (recommend these 3 for beginners)
5. Hover → **Preview** → show preview with your own content
6. Click **Install** → **Activate**
7. Visit front-end — *wow moment*: "See? Instant new design"
8. Show **how to delete unused themes**: Appearance → Themes → click unused theme → Delete (keep only 1-2)

Say this:

> "Don't install 10 themes to 'try'. Install 1, preview others. Too many themes slow down your site and confuse you. Pick ONE today."

■ *If install fails, check internet/hosting space — tell them to type "STUCK" in chat.*

Block 3 — Block Themes vs Classic Themes: The Big Concept (10 min)

> ■ This is the #2 beginner confusion after Posts vs Pages.

Simple explanation:

> "Classic themes = old way. You customize via **Appearance** → **Customize**. Block themes = new way (since 2022). You customize EVERYTHING with blocks — header, footer, everything — via **Appearance** → **Editor**. It's called Full Site Editing (FSE)."

Side-by-side comparison (share on screen):

	Classic Themes	Block Themes (FSE)
Example	Astra, GeneratePress, OceanWP	Twenty Twenty-Four, Spectra One, Blocksy (FSE mode)
Customization	Appearance → Customize	Appearance → Editor
Header/Footer	Theme options / Widgets	Edited as blocks
Page Builder needed?	Often yes (Elementor)	No, blocks are enough
Future?	Still works, but declining	Recommended for beginners now
How to identify?	Shows "Customize" menu	Shows "Editor" menu

Live demo:

1. Activate a Classic theme (Astra) → show **Appearance** → **Customize** appears
2. Activate a Block theme (Twenty Twenty-Four) → show **Appearance** → **Editor** appears
3. Tell them: *"For this course, we will use a Block Theme — Twenty Twenty-Four — so everyone is on same page"*

Block 4 — Site Editor Basics (15 min)

Step 1: Open Site Editor (2 min)

- Appearance → **Editor**
- Tour the left sidebar: **Navigation, Styles, Pages, Templates, Patterns**

Step 2: Styles — Make it Yours (7 min)

- Click **Styles** (paintbrush icon)
- Change **Colors**: Pick a palette or set custom primary color
- Change **Typography**: Heading font, Body font, sizes
- Show live preview on right — changes instantly
- Click **Save**

Step 3: Branding — Logo & Site Identity (3 min)

- Click **Patterns** → **Header** or **Templates** → **Header**
- Add **Site Logo** block → upload logo (or use Site Title text for now)
- Add **Site Title** and **Tagline** if not already there

Step 4: Header & Footer Template (3 min)

- Templates → **Header** → edit navigation, add/remove menu items
- Templates → **Footer** → edit copyright text
- Emphasize: *"You are editing the template — this change applies to ALL pages"*
- **Save** → View site

Block 5 — Cleanup + Q&A + Homework (10 min)

Mini recap quiz (chat-based):

- *"Where do we install new themes?"* → Appearance → Themes → Add New
- *"Block theme uses Customize or Editor?"* → Editor
- *"Does changing theme delete posts?"* → No
- *"Where do we change colors and fonts in block theme?"* → Appearance → Editor → Styles
- Answer "STUCK" students (usually: can't find Editor, logo too big, changes not saving — clear cache)
- Assign homework
- **Teaser for Class 5:** *"Next class we go deep into the Block Editor — Gutenberg blocks, columns, images — to make beautiful posts!"*

■ Homework Sheet (share with students)

Class 4 Homework — Due before Class 5 ■

#	Task	✓
1	Install and Activate **Twenty Twenty-Four** (or Astra/Blocksy if you prefer)	■
2	Delete unused themes (keep max 2)	■
3	Go to Appearance → Editor → Styles → set your **brand colors** (pick 2)	■
4	Set your **fonts** in Styles → Typography	■
5	Add a **Site Logo** or make Site Title prominent in Header template	■
6	Edit Footer → change copyright text to your name/year	■
7	Take a screenshot of your new homepage	■

■ **Bonus challenge:** Try 2 more themes (preview only), then decide which one you love. Install **Starter Templates** pattern for inspiration.

■ **Submission:** Post before/after screenshot (Class 3 site vs Class 4 themed site) in class group/chat.

■ Common Issues & Quick Fixes (for the teacher)

Problem	Fix
Can't find Appearance → Editor, only Customize	They activated a Classic theme. Ask them to activate Twenty Twenty-Four
Changes in Editor not showing on live site	Click Save, then Ctrl+F5 / incognito. Check cache plugin if installed
Logo looks huge / blurry	Re-upload 300x300px PNG, or adjust image size in Editor. Use SVG if possible
Header disappeared after edit	Templates → Header → Reset or restore revision (clock icon)
Site looks broken after theme switch	Classic theme may need Customizer setup. Switch back to Twenty Twenty-Four and re-save
Student installed 5+ themes	Guide to delete extras — keep only active + Twenty Twenty-Four as fallback

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■ Full 2-Week Syllabus (context for where Class 4 fits)

Day	Class	Topic	Key Deliverable
1	Hosting Basics	Domains, hosting, DNS basics, Hostinger hPanel tour	—
2	WP Dashboard Intro	Tour of wp-admin, what each menu does	—
3	Install & First Setup	Auto Installer, settings, posts vs pages	Live site + 1 page + 1 post
4	**Themes** ■■ *this one*	Installing/activating themes, block vs classic, Site Editor basics	Theme chosen & activated + branded colors/logo
5	Block Editor Deep Dive	Gutenberg: blocks, patterns, columns, images	Nicely formatted post
6	Building a Home Page	Full page layout together: hero, sections, buttons	Finished Home page
7	Navigation & Branding	Menus, header/footer, logo, site identity, favicon	Complete site navigation
8	Plugins	What/why plugins, install essentials (security, SEO)	2–3 plugins installed
9	Forms & Media	Contact form plugin, image optimization, media library	Working contact form
10	Final Project	Each student builds a small site (e.g., a baby-products store like "BabyCocoon")	■ Finished website

Tip: Record every class and share the recording + this lesson plan's homework sheet in your class group. Beginners rewatch theme switching a LOT.